BRICS counterhegemonic activity in the WTO has occurred well within the broader agenda of neoliberalism. According to one of the coordinators of the Our World Is Not for Sale civil society network (James 2013), the mid-2013 promotion of the Brazilian ambassador to the WTO, Roberto Azevêdo, to become the body's director-general, represented a debilitating form of co-optation, sure to lessen resistance by the South's 'G110' bloc. The cancellation of Europe–South African Bilateral Investment Treaties by South African Trade Minister Rob Davies was considered to be an inspiring case of standing up to the West, but as an exception which proved the rule. This manoeuvre also confirmed Pretoria's defence of regional domination against EU intrusion into its immediate hinterland, the Southern African Customs Union. By December 2014, the main provisions of a new South African investment law that would have protected local sovereignty were withdrawn under pressure from corporations. And indeed within the WTO, in December 2013, Azevêdo was able to arrange a WTO ministerial agreement that put the organisation back on track. This was a notable accomplishment given the failure of his predecessor, Pascal Lamy, who hailed from (and invariably supported) the European Union during prior failed efforts. On the trade front, aside from sanctions against Russia resulting in a slight reorientation to China, as well as the insistence by health professionals and activists that generic medicines production be retained in India, Brazil and South Africa, virtually all the trade-related processes involving BRICS were aimed at strengthening the global corporate agenda. The same proved true for BRICS corporate direct investments.

In this context, what may emerge from the networking of the sub-imperialist elites, as witnessed in the BRICS bloc in its initial formation period, is an agenda that more systematically confirms super-exploitative practices within their hinterlands. Just as the political carving of Africa in Berlin at the 1884–85 conference hosted by Bismarck drew the continent's irrational boundaries mainly in order to benefit extractive enterprises – mining houses and plantations as well as construction firms associated with England, France, Portugal, Belgium and Germany – BRICS appears to follow colonial and neo-colonial tracks. Identifying port, bridge, road, rail, hydropower and other infrastructure projects in the same image, the BRICS 2013 Durban summit had as its aim the continent's *economic* carve-up, unburdened – now as then – by what would be derided as 'Western' concerns about democracy and human rights. More than a dozen African heads of state were present as collaborators. The New Partnership for Economic Development and the African Peer Review Mechanism were often alleged to serve as African homegrown policing mechanisms for such infrastructure, but were